

3.4.1 Strategies for understanding

3.4.1.1 Ignoring words which are not needed

Many tasks contain words which are not essential for an understanding of the main points of the text. What is important in the text is often presented more than once, in different ways: the student may not understand a point in one form of words and understand it fully in another.

3.4.1.2 Using the visual and verbal context

The skilled reader can find many clues about the purpose and content of a text from a study of the layout, the title, the length, the typeface and any related pictures.

When reading and listening, students can learn to infer the meaning of new words from the verbal context. For example, someone who did not know the word *camioneta* might be able, after some appropriate practice, to deduce from the following context that it is some sort of vehicle: *La camioneta salió de la carretera y chocó con un árbol.*

3.4.1.3 Making use of grammatical markers and categories

Students will be helped to master all these strategies if, when reading and listening, they learn to use such clues as the plural forms of nouns and verbs, the way verbs change to form tenses, word order and other such features to help them recognise to which category (verb, noun, adjective etc) an unknown word belongs. This can be a considerable help in making intelligent guesses about the meaning of the word.

3.4.1.4 Making use of the social and cultural context

Another aid to the drawing of correct inferences is for students to bear in mind that there are regularities in the real world which make it possible to anticipate what people may say or write about it. The ability to predict occurrences in the real world makes it possible to anticipate words, and their meaning, in a given context. This is one reason why it is important for a Spanish course to develop awareness and understanding of countries and communities where Spanish is spoken.

For example, the student who knows that the *Día de Reyes* is the 6 January will be able to deduce from *día 5 de enero, víspera de Reyes* that *víspera* means 'the eve of' or 'the day before'.

3.4.1.5 Using common patterns within Spanish

Knowledge of the following patterns of word formation in Spanish can help to understand a text.

- *-ito/-ita* and *-illo/-illa* endings used to form diminutives (eg *casa – casita, perro – perrito, mesa – mesilla*)
- *-ón/ona* suffix used to form augmentatives (eg *cuchara – cucharón, mujer – mujerona*)

- *-mente* suffix used to form adverbs (eg *rápido – rápidamente, total – totalmente*)
- *re-* prefix (eg *leer – releer, crear – recrear*)
- *-ero/-era* endings and *ería* ending (eg *reloj – relojero, fruta – frutero – frutería*)
- *des-* and *in-* prefixes (eg *hacer – deshacer, conocido – desconocido, correcto – incorrecto, posible – imposible*)
- *-able* ending applied to verbs (eg *imaginar – imaginable, admirar – admirable*)
- *-ión* and *-ción* endings applied to verbs (eg *producir – producción, animar – animación*)
- *-oso/-osa* ending applied to nouns (eg *montaña – montañoso, ruido – ruidoso, lluvia – lluvioso*)
- *-dor/-dora* ending applied to verbs to form nouns and adjectives (eg *hablar – hablador, trabajar – trabajador*)
- *-eza, -dad* and *-ura* endings applied to adjectives (eg *limpio – limpieza, pobre – pobreza, sucio – suciedad, honesto – honestidad, hermoso – hermosura, loco – locura*)
- Compound words (eg *abrelatas, abrebotellas*)
- *-ante* and *-iente* endings applied to verbs (eg *protestar – protestante, corresponder – correspondiente*).

3.4.1.6 Using cognates and near-cognates

A few 'false friends' (eg *largo, sensible, actual*) make it necessary to use this strategy with care and in collaboration with the strategy of using the visual and verbal context above. However, for each 'false friend' there are very many 'good friends' of which anglophone learners of Spanish can make good use. These fall into two main categories: cognates and near-cognates.

Cognates

There are very many words which have exactly the same form, and essentially the same meaning, in Spanish and in English (eg *animal, horrible, central, principal*). When such words occur in context, students can be expected to understand them in English and Spanish.

Near-cognates

Students will also be expected to understand words which meet the above criteria but which differ slightly in their written form in Spanish, usually by the addition of one or more accents and/or the omission of a letter (eg *confusión, explosión, oficial*).

3.4.1.7 Using common patterns between Spanish and English

There are thousands of words in Spanish which, although not having exactly the same form as the English word, can easily be understood with the application of a few, simple rules. When words which can be understood using the rules below occur in context, students will be expected to understand them.

Pattern	Examples
The Spanish word adds an <i>-o</i> (and sometimes an accent) or changes a final <i>'-e'</i> in English to an <i>-o</i>	<i>aspecto, automático, económico, activo, decisivo</i>
The Spanish word adds an <i>-a</i> (and sometimes an accent)	<i>lista, idiota</i>
Words ending in <i>'-ist'</i> in English often end in <i>-ista</i> in Spanish	<i>pianista, comunista,</i>
Spanish changes a final <i>'-e'</i> to an <i>-a</i>	<i>medicina</i>

Pattern	Examples
The Spanish word adds an -e	<i>aire, arte</i>
Words which end in <i>-fa</i> or <i>-ia</i> in Spanish and '-y' in English	<i>biología, economía, tragedia</i>
Words which end in <i>-or</i> in Spanish and '-our' in English	<i>honor, vigor, labor</i>
Verbs which add <i>-ar, -er</i> or <i>-ir</i> in the infinitive in Spanish or change a final '-e' in English to one of these endings	<i>admirar, confirmar, reservar, servir</i>
Verbs which end with <i>-ar</i> in the infinitive in Spanish and with '-ate' in English	<i>decorar, cultivar, activar</i>
Words which, in addition to the points above, have minor spelling changes between English and Spanish to accord with the Spanish phonetic system of spelling	<i>filosofía, psicología, gráfico, fotografía, cuestión</i>
Words in which <i>t</i> in Spanish corresponds to 'th' in English	<i>teatro, catedral, auténtico, autor</i>
Spanish adverbs ending in <i>-mente</i> which end with '-ly' in English	<i>completamente, especialmente, generalmente</i>
Words which end in <i>-oso/-osa</i> in Spanish and '-ous' in English	<i>fabuloso, religioso, furioso</i>
Words where '-tion' in English is replaced by <i>-ción</i> in Spanish	<i>acción, inspección, integración</i>
Words ending in <i>-ante</i> or <i>-iente</i> in Spanish corresponding to English '-ant' and '-ent'	<i>protestante, correspondiente, deficiente</i>
Words where '-nce' in English becomes <i>-ncia</i> in Spanish	<i>evidencia, vigilancia, inteligencia, ocurrencia</i>
Adjectives where '-ical' in English becomes <i>ico/ica</i> in Spanish	<i>físico, óptico, fanático</i>
Words where 'oun' in English is replaced by <i>-un</i> in Spanish	<i>anunciar, pronunciar</i>
Words where <i>des-</i> in Spanish is replaced by 'dis-' in English	<i>desconectar, desconcertar, desembarcar</i>
Words which end in <i>-dad</i> or <i>-tad</i> in Spanish and '-ty' in English	<i>capacidad, sociedad, solemnidad, hospitalidad, libertad</i>
Adjectives ending in <i>-ense</i> which compare with English equivalents ending in '-an' or indicating a place of origin	<i>canadiense, londinense</i>
Words where an intervocalic <i>-d-</i> in Spanish is replaced by '-t-' in English	<i>senador, ecuador, operador, maduro</i>
The English word adds an extra letter or letters	<i>cine, clima, militar, avance</i>

Pattern	Examples
The Spanish word adds an epenthetic e- before words beginning with 's' + consonant	<i>esnob, especial, estéreo</i>
Words where a single vowel in English is replaced by a diphthong in Spanish	<i>sentimiento, compartimiento, puerto</i>

Strategies such as those outlined above will generally be more easily applied in reading than in listening, as reading offers more opportunities to slow down, look at unknown items at some leisure and study the context. However, the general strategies for understanding listed above can be used successfully in listening to Spanish.

In order to hear accurately, students should have the relationship between the spoken and written language brought to their attention. Words which **look** the same in Spanish and English may **sound** different and conversely, words with similar sounds may be written very differently in the two languages. For example, the Spanish word *circuito* looks very similar to its English counterpart but is pronounced quite differently while *rosbif* sounds very like the English phrase from which it is derived but looks very different when written down.